

Rasalhague
28 SunsCebalrai
43 SunsSabik
68 Suns

OPHIUCHUS

THE SERPENT HOLDER

OPHIUCHUS IS A LARGE CONSTELLATION THAT LIES ON THE CELESTIAL EQUATOR. IT EXTENDS FROM HERCULES IN THE NORTH TO SCORPIUS AND SAGITTARIUS IN THE SOUTH.

Ophiuchus represents a legendary healer called Aesculapius, who was reputed to be able to revive the dead. In the sky, he is depicted holding a snake (a traditional symbol of healing) in the form of the constellation Serpens.

Although large, the constellation is not particularly prominent. Its brightest star is second-magnitude Rasalhague (Alpha Ophiuchi), which marks Ophiuchus's head. Its most celebrated star is Barnard's Star, a faint (10th-magnitude) red dwarf a mere 5.9 light-years away. Ophiuchus contains numerous globular clusters, of which M10 and M12 are the easiest to see through a small telescope. The Sun passes through Ophiuchus in the first half of December each year but it is not regarded by many as a traditional constellation of the zodiac (see pp.92–93).

▷ Twin Jet Nebula

Two lobes of shimmering gas stream outward at speeds greater than 620,000 miles per hour (a million km per hour) from a central binary star, creating the butterfly-like shape seen in this Hubble Space Telescope image.

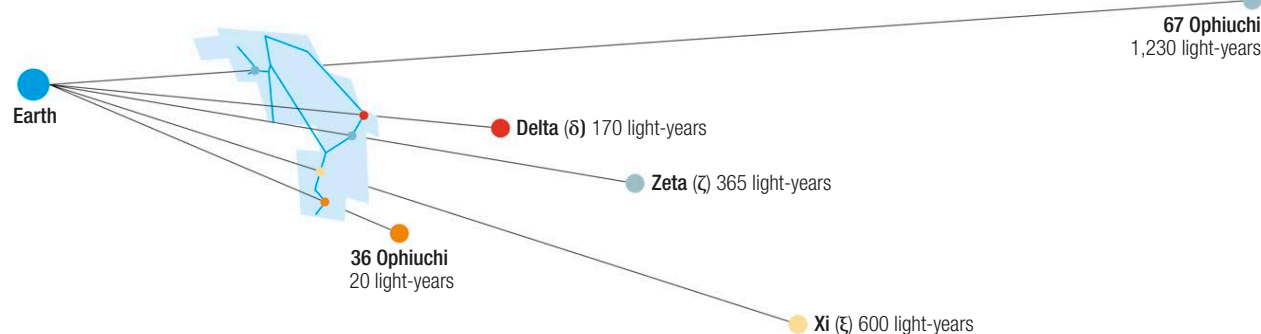
▽ Star distances

The closest pattern star, at about 20 light-years from Earth, is the binary pair 36 Ophiuchi. The most distant is 67 Ophiuchi, which is 60 times further away, at about 1,230 light-years from Earth.



△ NGC 6369

Seen here through the Hubble Space Telescope, this planetary nebula, popularly known as the Little Ghost, consists of a ring of gas about a light-year across, illuminated by ultraviolet light from the central core.



KEY DATA

Size ranking 11

Brightest stars Rasalhague
(α) 2.1, Sabik (η) 2.4

Genitive Ophiuchi

Abbreviation Oph

Highest in sky at 10pm
June–July

Fully visible 59°N–75°S



CHART 4

MAIN STARS

Rasalhague Alpha (α) Ophiuchi
Blue-white giant

☼ 2.1 ↔ 49 light-years

Cebalrai Beta (β) Ophiuchi
Orange giant

☼ 2.8 ↔ 82 light-years

Delta (δ) Ophiuchi
Red giant

☼ 2.8 ↔ 170 light-years

Zeta (ζ) Ophiuchi
Blue-white subdwarf

☼ 2.6 ↔ 365 light-years

Sabik Eta (η) Ophiuchi
Blue-white subdwarf

☼ 2.4 ↔ 88 light-years

Barnard's Star
Red dwarf

☼ 9.5 ↔ 5.9 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Kepler's Star

Remains of a supernova seen in October 1604

M10

Globular cluster

M12

Globular cluster

NGC 6369

Planetary nebula, also known as the Little Ghost

NGC 6633

Open cluster

IC 4665

Open cluster

Pipe Nebula

Dark nebula

Twin Jet Nebula (Minkowski 2–9)

Bipolar planetary nebula